

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1328

By Moody

A RESOLUTION to honor and celebrate the 200th anniversary of the Tabernacle Kinfolks Camp Meeting.

WHEREAS, in July 2026, the Taylor family will hold its 200th annual camp meeting in Haywood County, commonly known as the "Tabernacle Kinfolks Camp Meeting," which is a direct lineage from the traditions that began prior to 1773 at the tabernacle built by Colonel Edmund Taylor in Mecklenburg County, Virginia; and

WHEREAS, Colonel Taylor was a third-generation Virginian, an Anglican, and a leader in his community; he was on the Committees of Communication and Safety for Mecklenburg County prior to and during the Revolutionary War, a job that was "not for the faint of heart." Taylor's Ferry, across the Roanoke River, was a supply route serving the Southern Army commanded by General Nathanael Greene; and

WHEREAS, the Taylors became "Methodists" before there was a Methodist denomination, welcoming circuit riders into their homes as early as 1775, forming societies, building gathering places, and embracing all the peculiarities of Methodism; famous circuit rider and first Bishop of the Methodist Church, Francis Asbury, preached at the 1780 camp meeting at the tabernacle on Colonel Taylor's property; and

WHEREAS, in 1784, the year the Methodist Episcopal Church was founded in America, Colonel Taylor deeded the gathering place he had built near what is now Townsville, North Carolina, to the Methodist Episcopal Church and named it Tabernacle M.E. Church; and

WHEREAS, by 1817, the Reverend Howell Lewis Taylor, a son of Colonel Taylor, had filled his father's role in the community and enlarged that role in the Methodist Church. He was ordained but never took up a circuit, preferring to be of service to those in his community; and

WHEREAS, in 1817, two of Reverend Howell Taylor's sons, John and Richard, decided to move west for new opportunities. Reverend Howell, at the age of sixty-three, joined them on their migration to the frontier of Tennessee; they crossed the Appalachian Mountains and climbed the steep landscape onto the Cumberland Plateau; and

WHEREAS, in 1817, these Taylors settled as far west as they could go, to Montgomery County, near the Red River, west of Clarksville. That same year, the Red River area became the epicenter of the Second Great Awakening, where thousands attended the same type of camp meeting events as the Taylors had begun in Virginia; the Taylors brought their tradition of Methodist camp meetings to every community where they settled; and

WHEREAS, in 1818, the Taylors were joined in Montgomery County by John Williams and family, neighbors from Virginia; and

WHEREAS, from 1805 to 1818, the Chickasaw Nation ceded portions of their hunting lands in western Tennessee to the United States in exchange for property west of the Mississippi River; in 1823, Haywood County was established from within the Chickasaw Cessions; and

WHEREAS, in 1825, Richard Taylor bought 745 acres in Haywood County from John Poston in Montgomery County; the Taylors were the third Anglo-Americans to have deed to the property; and

WHEREAS, in 1826, the Taylors and Williamses brought their families and households, including enslaved peoples, across the Cumberland and Tennessee rivers and down the vale to Haywood County; they were the first to homestead northeast of Brownsville with some goods sent by the river and the rest by wagon; and

WHEREAS, the very first day that the Taylors were on their Haywood County property, they were joined by two circuit riders of the Methodist Church, Greenbury Garrett and Richard

Hutson, who rejoiced in seeing the others and were committed to building churches and starting Methodist societies; and

WHEREAS, in the first year, the Taylors built cabins, barns, pens, cribs, and fences for three homesteads and constructed a church on Richard Taylor's property. They named their church New Hope; it was built of split logs, large enough so that all, Blacks and whites, could attend services together; and

WHEREAS, a Methodist society, including like-hearted families—the Williamses, Barcrofts, Curries, Jacocks, and others—immediately formed around the church with all the peculiarities of that denomination: community gatherings for singing and shouting, confession and conversion, preaching and praying, and in an immersive setting: camp meetings; and

WHEREAS, by 1832, all of Reverend Howell Taylor's children with their households had joined their father and brothers in western Tennessee, and a larger church was built on Richard Taylor's property. It was nicely hewn of logs and was, for the times, excelled by none, or at least few, in the land; the name was changed to "Tabernacle Methodist Church," which was the name of the home church in Virginia; and

WHEREAS, in 1847, an even larger church was built to accommodate the growing congregation; with an addition and several remodels over the years, this church still welcomes hundreds of kinfolks from all over the United States and the world for the annual Tabernacle Kinfolks Camp Meeting, while continuing to serve the local congregation throughout the year; and

WHEREAS, Reverend Howell Lewis Taylor, son of Colonel Edmund Taylor, and his descendants, along with their neighbors and their descendants, have continued to stand for old Methodism and to keep camp meetings from their years in Virginia, through their years in Montgomery County, and through their 200 years in Haywood County; and

WHEREAS, we recognize that the importance the Taylor family's ancestors placed on gathering community together in camp meetings for spiritual growth and deep fellowship beautifully endures in their annual Tabernacle Kinfolks Camp Meeting; and

WHEREAS, we also recognize that Tabernacle Kinfolks Camp Meeting exists to encourage and foster the faith journey of each participant, individually and collectively, and that it is a community determined to continue its legacy of belonging and kinship that intentionally seeks a deeper connection with God and with each other, even to the remotest generation; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the members of the Tabernacle Kinfolks Camp Meeting on maintaining their family traditions and Methodist heritage for 200 years in Haywood County and for 250 years of history in these United States of America, wishing them Godspeed as they carry on this wonderful legacy and hope that they will continue to value and recreate this treasured experience for another quarter-millennium.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.